

Technology is truly personal

As many of you know, we've been on a massive hiring drive for the past couple of months. In almost every issue we slipped in a blank page, which was a clever call (we think) for applications from our readers. A lot of you wrote in saying you have what it takes to fill that blank page. The applications kept flowing in by the dozens and we had to reject quite a few. Sorry guys.

We eventually found the chosen ones who will bring balance to the 'force' (sorry, couldn't resist), but this column isn't about how difficult it is to get into Digit (quite difficult in case you were wondering), it's more about a particular insight I had while interviewing the many candidates who applied.

One of the most common questions we ask here at Digit is "what does technology mean to you?" or in other words "what is technology to you?". A seemingly innocuous question, it invariably foxes almost everyone.

Once they recover from their deer-in-the-headlights moment, the interviewees go on to define their understanding of technology. We've got a whole multitude of answers so far including absurd gems like "for me technology is God!" (we really thought it was Google).

For most, technology is smartphones. It's unbelievable the number of hours people spend on XDA forums, rooting / jailbreaking their phones, customising the look and feel, and generally tinkering around with a device that was primarily meant to be just a means of communication.

The older generation of geeks – a dying breed now – think PCs are synonymous with technology (I might be one of them, but I'm too busy playing *Borderlands 2* to care). Some DIY enthusiasts we've spoken to who live and breathe electronics, microcontrollers, and circuits, believe robotics and engineering is technology.

My friends at CERN and JNCASR (sorry I just have to brag) think technology is an entirely different ballgame. Understandable right? I have friends working in industries that are so far removed from anything tech such as artists, linguists, gym trainers – for them, technology is something as simple as social media.

The revelation though is that if technology can mean so many things to so many people –

it perhaps means technology truly is personal. Gives a new meaning to the term "personal technology", doesn't it? Incidentally it also happens to be the space your favourite magazine mainly dabbles in.

And it makes sense too, considering how emotional we get about technology. The PC Master Race, Android vs. iOS, Playstation vs. Xbox – these are just small examples of how caught up we get with our technology.

The more I thought about it, the closer I got to the truth: Technology is not personal. It never is.

Tech is just tech. It is we who make it personal.

Like with the place you call home – history played its part and decided that this is to be your motherland – your ancestors paid the price (sometimes) with blood and wars and famine. Now you live here and call it your own and it is personal to you – to you, your country means something in a unique way (else it's just a piece of land, right?).

Even with tech, it's how you use it that makes it personal – you tend to own it after you use it. HTML is just code – the way you once used it to create your blog (years ago) suddenly makes it personal to you. A phone is just a phone, then you buy it, you buy into its ecosystem and suddenly it's your phone. At a broader level, think about how rockets propel satellites, but could (and sadly do) propel warheads too.

Like most things, technology is just a tool. Once you adopt it to serve your needs it becomes personal to you.

To conclude I leave you with the same question, not as a test (which was the purpose of the question when we put it to our applicants), but as a way to get some interesting opinions:

What is technology to you?



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"One of the most common questions we ask here at Digit is *what does technology mean to you?*"

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